RECONSTRUCTION · MISSISSIPPI, 1869–1873

SETTLING UP: FIELD NOTES

Name _____

Family name in the game _____

Date / period _____

How to use this sheet

1. Play the game. You are Robert, a free farmer.
2. When you reach a **STOP**, pause and fill it in. Each stop says what you'll see on the screen.
3. Most answers are on the screen. Circle, fill in the blank, or copy the number.

Keep asking: Can you be free if you can't leave?

In plain words	Blue box: explains what just happened
Hannah's tally	Top bar: the family's own count of the money
Almanac	Top bar: cotton prices, year by year
Journal	Top bar: everything said, and the word list

STOP 1 · THE CONTRACT

January 1869 · the big house on the hill

Mr. Holliday reads the contract to you before you make your mark (an X).

a. Mr. Holliday gives the family land, a _____ , a _____ , tools, and seed.

b. The family keeps _____ of the cotton, but only after he is paid.

c. Until the debt is paid, the crop belongs to _____ . That claim is a _____ .

Word bank: half · lien · mule · cabin · Mr. Holliday

STOP 2 · THE STORE

Spring 1869 · "Furnish for the year"

a. Which basket did you choose? ◯ Lean ◯ Basic ◯ Extra Cost: $ _____

b. When does the family pay for it? ◯ Today, in cash ◯ At Christmas, out of the cotton

c. Read the warning in red. What happens to a family that buys Lean year after year?

_____

STOP 3 · THE FIELD

Spring 1869 · the Almanac opens

a. In the Almanac, what was cotton worth per bale in 1866? $ _____ In 1868? $ _____

◯ Rising ◯ Falling

b. How many acres of corn did you plant? _____ (most allowed: 5)

c. Finish the sentence: Cotton can pay the _____ , but corn _____ .

STOP 4 · THE SCALE

Fall 1869 · the big dial at the gin

Watch the needle. Then look for the dashed mark labeled "Hannah's string."

	HANNAH'S STRING		HIS SCALE		POUNDS HE DIDN'T COUNT
a.	_____	−	_____	=	_____

b. Who reads the scale? _____ Can Robert check it? ◯ Yes ◯ No

STOP 5 · SETTLING UP

Christmas 1869 · Mr. Holliday's porch

His book adds up line by line. Copy the bottom line of the equation.

	THE CROP BROUGHT IN		HE CHARGED		HIS BOOK SAYS	HANNAH'S TALLY SAYS
a.	_____	−	_____	=	_____	_____

b. Click "Leave the Holliday place." What happens, and why?

_____

_____

Contract excerpt adapted from the 1882 Grimes Family Papers (SHEG)

STOP 6

EACH CHRISTMAS

1870–1873 · one row every time you settle up

Year	Basket L / B / E	Event card what happened this year	Price per bale "He sold the cotton at..."	His book says	Hannah's tally	Owing?
1870			$	$	$	Yes / No
1871			$	$	$	Yes / No
1872			$	$	$	Yes / No
1873			$	$	$	Yes / No

a. Which number was lower every year?

◯ His book ◯ Hannah's tally

b. Price per bale from 1869 to 1873:

◯ Went up ◯ Went down

c. Pick one event card. What happened to the family's money, and whose fault was it?

_____

STOP 7

THE AUDIT

After 1873 · his book next to the honest book

The audit shows the hidden rules. Copy your family's numbers.

a. Extra paid for store prices (credit markup): $ _____

b. Cotton his scale didn't count, all five years: _____ lb

c. With honest books, could your family have rented a farm? ◯ Yes ◯ No

d. Which hidden rule cost your family the most? ◯ Store markup ◯ Short scale ◯ Interest

> *"A man that didn't know how to count would always lose. He might lose anyhow. They didn't give no itemized statement. No, you just had to take their word."*
>
> Henry Blake, formerly enslaved, interviewed for the Federal Writers' Project, Arkansas, 1930s

e. How is Henry Blake's story like your family's? _____

WORDS

MATCH THEM

Use the Journal's word list if you're stuck

_____ **Sharecropper**

_____ **Lien**

_____ **Furnish**

_____ **Credit**

_____ **Settling up**

_____ **Carried debt**

A Food and supplies from the planter's store for the year

B Money still owed after Christmas, moved onto next year

C A farmer paid with part of the crop, not with wages

D The planter's legal claim on the crop until the debt is paid

E Taking things now and paying later, at a higher price

F The Christmas reckoning: the crop against everything owed

LAST STOP

YOUR ANSWER

One paragraph: can you be free if you can't leave?

T **Topic:** Sharecroppers like Robert were / were not free because...

E **Evidence:** In my game, ... (use one number from your sheet)

A **Analysis:** This shows the system kept families in place because...

Dollar amounts in the game are simplified; the system they show is real.